had a base in Colombo as well. *The Hindu* described them as ‘a patriotic band of merchants and others in Tuticorin and Colombo’.[136] These Tamil merchants were an important interest group, and in 1930 they established a Tamil daily, *Veerakesari* in Colombo with which VOC had a close association writing regularly for it. *Veerakesari*, in turn raised funds for his benefit. This close bonding nearly twenty years after SSNCo’s demise speaks for the enormous goodwill that VOC commanded among the trading community in Colombo.

In December 1908, the SSNCo’s appeal provided the following details about the investments: R 4,50,000 lakh in Madras Presidency, Rs 75,000 from Bengal and Bombay, ‘our countrymen in Ceylon nearly as much, and those in Burma, Africa, etc. over a lac and a half’.[137]

Unfortunately, further details on the geographical spread of shareholding are not available.

Coasting Along the Coromandel

Having raised some capital, what were SSNCo’s business plans? The company put on a brave face in the light of the campaign and the resources mobilized. As we noted above, the company, in its annual report, had exuded a guarded optimism. It now proposed a reoriented strategy and new operational plans.

Drawing confidence from the fact that the trade between India and Ceylon was exclusively under the command of Indian merchants, an overwhelming majority of whom were patriotic, SSNCo stated that with the infusion of capital ‘the success of this company will be a signal achievement …’[138] However, unable to make a dent in the passenger service, SSNCo decided to focus on cargo.

SSNCo’s optimism was echoed by the press. Entirely at odds with the government’s expectation of an imminent collapse, *The Hindu* was full of cheer: ‘The business prospects of the Company are brighter than ever before. If the country will respond promptly to the call now made, the success of this Swadeshi Company will forever be assured which would